Ghazni was making his infamous raids, commented that contemporary Indian scholars were so full of themselves that they were unwilling to learn anything from the rest of the world. He then contrasts this attitude with that of their ancestors.

Given this cultural shift, Indian merchants became increasingly shore-based, while shipping passed mostly into the hands of Arabs. However, there were also Jews, Persians and even the Chinese. Ibn Batuta saw a number of Chinese ships in Calicut (Kozhikode) and he describes a military junk that must have accompanied a merchant fleet. It was large enough to accommodate a thousand men, six hundred sailors and four hundred men-at-arms. In other words, Ibn Batuta was exploiting a very active trading network on his journeys. It is testimony to the vigour and sophistication of this network that Ibn Batuta met a man from Ceuta, a city very close to his home town of Tangier, first in Delhi and then, accidentally, again in China.[34] Ibn Batuta may have been the one to write about his travels but the routes he took were well known to the world of Arab merchants.

Nonetheless, the spirit of ancient India was kept alive for several more centuries by the kingdoms of South East Asia. Angkor continued to be the capital of the Khmer empire till it was sacked by the Thais in 1431. Its ruins must be seen to be believed. Lesser known but equally interesting are the remains of the kingdom of Champa in Vietnam. The kingdom flourished till its capital Vijaya was sacked by Viet troops in 1471. A smaller Cham kingdom would limp along till it, too, was overrun in the late seventeenth century. Hindu temples built by the Chams are scattered across Vietnam—a few are still used by the tiny Balamon Cham community that continues to practise Hinduism (they number around 30,000). Sadly, the most important cluster of Cham temples in My Son was heavily bombed by the Americans during the Vietnam war. The site is now designated a UNESCO World Heritage site but frankly there is very little to see. The small museum at the entrance has some pre-war photographs that provide an idea of its former glory.

Perhaps the most vigorous of the India-inspired cultures, however, was that of Java. In the fourteenth century, the Majapahits of Java had